NYCEM
New York City Emergency Management



New York City Emergency Management

2026 Disaster Law Symposium

Law at the Crossroads – Strengthening Systems for a New Era of Disasters

Thursday, October 29, 2026

8:30 AM – 5:00 PM | John Jay College of Criminal Justice

This full-day event will bring together attorneys from all sectors, academic professionals, and policy experts from across the region who seek quality continuing legal education courses, professional development, and networking opportunities to explore the unique legal frameworks and ethical considerations that are present in the field of emergency management and disaster response.

The symposium will consist of CLE classes open to city, state, and federal attorneys and legal professionals from partner agencies involved in emergency management, mitigation, and public safety.

Sponsors

NYSBA NEW YORK STATE BAR ASSOCIATION

ACIAJJ
The Academy for Critical Incident Analysis
at John Jay College

New York City Law Department

JOHN JAY COLLEGE OF CRIMINAL JUSTICE
RESEARCH

Purpose and Impact

In an era of increasingly complex emergencies—ranging from natural disasters to public health crises to cyber threats—legal preparedness is essential to effective emergency management. The Disaster Law Symposium, hosted by NYCEM, is a timely initiative convening legal and policy professionals to examine legal frameworks, ethical questions, and interagency coordination challenges that arise during crises.

By fostering dialogue and training among attorneys, policymakers, and emergency managers, the symposium will enhance our city's legal readiness, support effective decision-making in emergencies, and ensure that services are delivered equitably, lawfully, and efficiently.

This event will:

- Provide Continuing Legal Education (CLE) accredited training to attorneys on emergency management law and compliance issues;
- Facilitate cross-agency and intergovernmental dialogue; and
- Strengthen partnerships with agencies on the local and state level.



Program Agenda

8:30 am – 9:00 am
Registration and Morning Reception

9:00 am – 9:30 am
Opening Remarks

9:30 am – 10:30 am
Algorithmic Response: Governing Artificial Intelligence and Emerging Technologies in Emergencies

CLE Description:

This course examines the expanding role of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies in emergency management and disaster legal practice. As jurisdictions adopt wider use and implementation of artificial intelligence and other emerging technologies, attorneys face new ethical and legal challenges. Panelists will assess how AI shapes public decision making, resource allocation, privacy considerations, and the legal rights of affected communities, particularly during moments of crisis when speed, accuracy, and bias mitigation are critical. The session explores risk governance, transparency, and accountability structures necessary to regulate AI tools used by governments, nonprofits, and private sector partners responding to disasters.

10:30 am – 10:45 am
Break

10:45 am – 11:45 am
Justice Under Pressure: Protecting Rights and Advancing Equity During Disasters

CLE Description:

This course explores the heightened vulnerability of civil liberties, due process, and equity during large scale disasters. When essential systems falter marginalized populations often experience disproportionate harm. Attorneys must navigate the tension between emergency operations and individual rights, ensuring legal protections remain intact even under extraordinary operational pressure. Panelists will analyze the ways disaster conditions can compound pre-existing inequities, discuss legal tools to safeguard rights, and examine strategies for advancing equitable outcomes through advocacy, planning and community partnership. One subject the panel will address is the Supreme Court's 1999 decision in Olmstead v. L.C., interpreting Title II of the ADA's integration mandate, including the potential impact of a recent opinion of the Federal Office of Legal Counsel's (OLC), which adopts a narrow view of how the ADA's integration mandate applies.

Program Agenda

11:45 am – 12 pm
Break

12:00 pm - 1:15 pm
Keynote Address & Lunch
Jeh Johnson, former Secretary of the Department of Homeland Security

1:30 pm – 2:30 pm
Ethical Duties When the Office Goes Dark: Continuity of Operations and Client Protection During Disasters

CLE Description:
This course focuses on the ethical and operational challenges attorneys face when disaster conditions disrupt law firm operations, government agencies, or legal service organizations. Whether the disruption stems from infrastructure failure, communication outages, or displacement of staff and clients, lawyers must ensure continuity of representation and protection of client interests. Panelists will evaluate ethical duties related to competence, communication, supervision, confidentiality, and safeguarding client property when normal workflows collapse. The session highlights practical continuity planning, emergency protocols, and resilience strategies for legal practitioners across all settings.

2:30 pm – 2:45 pm
Break

2:45 pm – 3:45 pm
The Next Disaster Landscape: Climate Change and Legal Preparedness for Cascading and Complex Risks

CLE Description:
This course examines the emerging horizon of multifaceted and cascading disaster risks, focusing on the role of climate change as a key factor in (or catalyst of) those risks. Attorneys must be prepared for scenarios where multiple crises interact, amplify harm, and destabilize legal systems. Panelists will explore the climate change threats to New York City; anticipate challenges in insurance, landlord/tenant, and housing; consider lessons on preparedness for climate disasters from other regions; and assess frameworks for collaboration across different sectors, multi-hazard planning, and legal readiness. The session emphasizes forward looking strategies that equip lawyers to advise clients, institutions, and communities in an era of compounding risks and systemic volatility.

4:00 pm – 5:00 pm
Networking Reception

Opening Remarks



Christina Farrell
Commissioner, New York City Emergency Management

Christina Farrell is a lifelong public servant with more than 23 years of experience working to improve the lives of New Yorkers before, during, and after emergencies. As Commissioner of the New York City Emergency Management Department (NYCEM), she helps lead the City's emergency preparedness, response, and recovery efforts and collaborates with City leadership and regional, state, and federal partners on emergency management matters.



Karol Mason
President, John Jay College

At John Jay College of Criminal Justice, President Karol V. Mason's student success vision increased graduation rates, strengthened academic achievement, and expanded career preparation. Mason founded the Future of Public Safety Initiative and drove creation of an anti-racist curriculum framework. Before joining John Jay College, She led the U.S. Department of Justice's Office of Justice Programs overseeing a $4 billion budget.



Taa Grays
President, New York State Bar Association

During her tenure, Grays will focus on implementing the association's strategic plan. In addition, Grays will focus on simplifying consumer terms and conditions, improving access to justice in Family Court, providing guidance concerning renewable and sustainable energy use, building more member resources on the use of generative artificial intelligence, and developing an archive showcasing the accomplishment of the association and its members in advancing the rule of law.



Nisha Agarwal
Commissioner, Mayor's Office for People with Disabilities

Nisha Agarwal works to advance accessibility, equity, and inclusion for New Yorkers with disabilities. Throughout her career in public service, advocacy, and law, Commissioner Agarwal has focused on expanding access and opportunity across communities, with leadership roles spanning public health, immigrant justice, and civic engagement.



Steven Banks
Corporation Counsel

Nominated by Mayor Zohran Kwame Mamdani on December 30, 2025, and confirmed by the New York City Council on February 12, 2026, Steven Banks is the 83rd Corporation Counsel of the City of New York. He leads the New York City Law Department, the nation's largest municipal law office, with more than 900 lawyers and 800 support professionals.

Artificial Intelligence Panel



Justice Patria Frias-Colón
Justice of the Supreme Court, Civil Term, Kings County

The Hon. Patria Frias-Colón was elected in 2022 as Justice of the Supreme Court, Civil Term of Kings County where she currently serves in the Medical Malpractice Part. Before this, she was the Supervising Judge for the Civil Court in Queens County and served in both the Civil Court of Kings County and Family Court of New York County.



Marissa J. Moran
Professor and Chair, Law and Paralegal Studies Department, New York City College of Technology, CUNY

Marissa Moran is a professor and chair of the Law and Paralegal Studies Department, New York City College of Technology, City University of New York, where she has over 20 years of legal education experience creating and teaching courses such as Legal Technology, Forensic Science & The Legal Process, Legal Document Preparation, Legal Ethics and Professional Responsibility, and Theatre of Law.



Susan Garcia Nofi
Legal Director, TechTonic Justice

Susan Garcia Nofi is TechTonic Justice's Legal Director. As an advocate, Susan has represented clients in housing, public benefits, employment, and disability rights matters. She also spent a decade working for the State of Connecticut Department of Labor as an Appeals Referee, as Board of Review legal staff, and most recently as Chair of the Board of Review and executive head of the appeals division.



Rebecca Lipman
Deputy Chief, Ethics and Compliance Division, New York City Law Department

Rebecca Lipman is the Deputy Chief of the Ethics and Compliance Division at the New York City Law Department. Rebecca joined the Legal Counsel Division of the Law Department in 2016 after clerking for the Honorable Anne E. Thompson in the District of New Jersey. Rebecca left the Law Department in 2021 to become the General Counsel for the Mayor's Office of Operations.

Justice Under Pressure Panel



Taa Grays
President, New York State Bar Association

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Jason Rivera
Professor and Chair, Department of Public Management, John Jay College of Criminal Justice

Dr. Jason Rivera is the Chair of the Section on Emergency and Crisis Management within the American Society for Public Administration. Over the last twenty years, he has worked in various disaster and national contexts helping to enhance the capacity of governments' emergency management systems. He has contributed to the development of emergency and disaster management policies at the local and state-levels in the United States, and at the national-level within The Gambia and El Salvador.



Jennifer Mathis
Deputy Director, Bazelon Center for Mental Health Law

Jennifer Mathis has worked at the Center since 1999 except for two periods of federal government service. Between December 2021 and January 2025, Jennifer served as a Deputy Assistant Attorney General in the Justice Department's Civil Rights Division, supervising the disability rights work among other functions. Jennifer served on the disability community negotiating team that worked with business community representatives to craft language that became the ADA Amendments Act and played a lead role in securing passage of the ADAAA.



Michael Wasser
Senior Counsel, New York City Law Department

Michael J. Wasser, Esq. is Senior Counsel in the Tax and Bankruptcy Litigation Division of the New York City Law Department. A committed advocate for disability inclusion, Michael serves on his office's Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Committee and led the effort to make the office the first public law office to sign the American Bar Association's Pledge for Change, advocating for attorneys with disabilities. He also serves as Vice President of the Board of Directors of the Brooklyn Center for Independence of the Disabled and on the Board of Directors of NMD United.

Keynote Address



Jeh Johnson
Former U.S. Secretary of Homeland Security (2013-2017)

In public life, Johnson was Secretary of Homeland Security (2013–2017) and General Counsel of the Department of Defense (2009–2012) in the Obama Administration, and General Counsel of the Department of the Air Force (1998–2001) in the Clinton Administration. Earlier, he was an Assistant United States Attorney in the Southern District of New York (1989–1991).

Johnson is the 2024 recipient of the Gold Medal, the New York State Bar Association's highest honor; a 2024 recipient of the National Law Journal's Lifetime Achievement Award; a 2022 recipient of the Ellis Island Medal of Honor; a 2021 recipient of the American Lawyer's Lifetime Achievement Award; and a 2018 recipient of the Ronald Reagan Peace Through Strength Award.

Continuity of Operations Panel



Justice Patria Frias-Colón
Justice of the Supreme Court, Civil Term, Kings County

The Hon. Patria Frias-Colón was elected in 2022 as Justice of the Supreme Court, Civil Term of Kings County where she currently serves in the Medical Malpractice Part. Before this, she was the Supervising Judge for the Civil Court in Queens County and served in both the Civil Court of Kings County and Family Court of New York County.



Clay Garner
Director of Continuity and Mission Assurance, New York City Emergency Management

Clay Garner serves as Director of Continuity and Mission Assurance at New York City Emergency Management. He leads citywide continuity and preparedness initiatives, with a focus on strengthening the resilience of essential services and improving readiness for disruptions. Garner also supports NYCEM's emergency operations during major incidents and planned events as a Planning Section Chief.



Seth M. Rosner
Principal, Seth M. Rosner, P.C.

Seth M. Rosner opened his solo practice in 2005, representing clients with personal injury matters and defending business owners involved in legal disputes. He also gives back to the community and was recognized for his pro-bono work helping victims devastated by Superstorm Sandy.

Cascading and Complex Risks Panel



Alessandra Jerolleman
Disaster Resilience and Adaptation Senior Fellow, Livelihoods Knowledge Exchange Network

Alessandra Jerolleman is the Disaster Resilience and Adaptation Senior Fellow at the Livelihoods Knowledge Exchange Network and is admitted to the Louisiana Bar. Dr. Jerolleman serves as the Part-Time Director of Research for the Center for Environment, Land and Law, at Loyola University New Orleans College of Law where she runs a Community Based Research Lab.



Hilary Meltzer
Chief, Environmental Law Division, New York City Law Department

Hilary Meltzer became Chief of the Environmental Law Division of the New York City Law Department in 2019 after serving as Deputy Chief for nine years and a member of that Division since 1992. She practices environmental and municipal law, focusing on a variety of infrastructure, land use, and policy issues facing New York City.



Brian Baer
Founder and Executive Director, The Elevated Studio

Brian Baer is the founder and executive director of The Elevated Studio which promotes social equality by expanding access to values-driven design that helps individuals and communities achieve economic and physical resilience and sustainability. Brian is a licensed architect with four decades of experience implementing sustainable, community-aided design solutions for a wide variety of projects across the United States.



Timothy J. Fennell
Managing Partner, Amdursky, Pelky, Fennell & Wallen, P.C.

Upon graduating from Albany Law School, Union University, in May of 1983, Tim joined the law firm of Leonard Amdursky. Tim was named a partner in 1987 and is currently the Managing Partner. Tim is admitted to both the New York State and Federal Courts and enjoys a busy practice in both civil and criminal law, with emphasis on litigation, trusts and estates, matrimonial law, and real estate. Tim has presented cases to the Court of Appeals and the United States Supreme Court.

Moderators



Sonja Orgias
Chief Counsel

Sonja Orgias has served as the Chief Counsel of New York City Emergency Management since August 2022. In her role, Ms. Orgias oversees the Office of the Chief Counsel comprised of three units: Legal Affairs, Civil and Human Rights and Records Management. She also provides legal guidance to the Commissioner, First Deputy Commissioner, and other executives.



Traci Wheelwright
Deputy Chief Counsel

Traci Wheelwright serves as Deputy Chief Counsel at New York City Emergency Management, where she leads a team of attorneys and professionals in providing strategic legal guidance on emergency response, civil rights, privacy, and procurement law. With over two decades of legal experience, Traci has built a distinguished career across city, state, and federal agencies. Her expertise spans rulemaking, litigation, public contracting, and compliance.



Dennis Boyd
Executive Civil and Human Rights Counsel

Since 2015 Mr. Boyd has worked in the Office of Chief Counsel at New York City Emergency Management. There he serves as Executive Civil and Human Rights Counsel, overseeing the agency's Disability and Access and Functional Needs program, which works to make emergency planning, preparedness, response and recovery inclusive of the needs of people who tend to be most adversely impacted by large scale emergencies.



Robert DeVoogd
Senior Agency Counsel and FOIL Officer

Rob DeVoogd is Senior Agency Counsel and FOIL officer at New York City Emergency Management. He has been with the agency for 8 years.



Lucette Moran
Agency Counsel

Lucette Moran has served as Agency Counsel in the Office of the Chief Counsel for New York City Emergency Management since November 2025. In her role, Moran conducts research and provides advice to executives and staff on strategic, legal, and policy issues. She engages in transactional work and advises on agency staff policy and conflicts of interest rules.

Special Thanks

Christina Farrell, NYCEM Commissioner
Ben Krakauer, NYCEM First Deputy Commissioner
Yokarina Duarte-Medina, NYCEM Chief of Staff
Nisha Agarwal, MOPD Commissioner
Dr. Jason Rivera, John Jay College
Mindy Bockstein, John Jay College
Dominique Mendez, John Jay College
Daniel Tambasco, NYSBA Mass Disaster Response Committee Chair
Seth Rosner, NYSBA Mass Disaster Response Committee Chair
June Witterschein, NYC Law Department Director of Professional Development
Londyn Graham, NYC Law Department Assistant Director of Professional Development
John Vigoa, NYC Mayor's Office of Media and Entertainment
Sara Rawshanara, MOPD Assistant Commissioner
Arthur Jacobs, NYC Digital Accessibility Coordinator
Mohamed Awadalla, NYCEM Intern
Paula Caquias, NYCEM Senior Advisor
Eric Smalls, NYCEM Chief Technology Officer
Toney Lewis, NYCEM Director of Information Technology
Aliou Bah, NYCEM Desktop Support Technician
Christopher Blanco, NYCEM Chief Financial Officer
Elisa Urena, NYCM Deputy Chief Financial Officer
Michael Miller, NYCEM Director of Finance
Kumarie Ramsaroop, NYCEM Deputy Director of Accounts Payable
Iskra Killgore, NYCEM Assistant Commissioner of Community Engagement
Moriah Washington, NYCEM Director of Community and Preparedness
Thea Paulucci, NYCEM Deputy Director of Communications
Krystal Vaquerano, NYCEM Social Media Content Specialist
Elijah Joseph-Muhammad, NYCEM Multimedia Content Specialist
Anthony Escoto, NYCEM Director of Volunteer Programs
Tyler Roosa, NYCEM Director of Public Warning